

ONE SMALL PROOF

Adapted from the short story "[One Small Proof](#)" by Ys Goldt

by

Ys Goldt

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CHARACTERS

TALOA	A young woman, age 18-23. Long black hair, light brown skin and dark brown eyes. Wearing a short skirt of natural plant fibres, no shirt. Many necklaces and bracelets and anklets made of shells and small drilled-shell beads in colours of cream, chalk white, warm beige, pale peach, soft pink, grey, brown and black.
TOMÁS	A Spanish sailor, age 19-25. Dark-blond hair falls to his neck; blue eyes. He wears a torn linen shirt and breeches, both salt-stained and soaked from the sea. Barefoot. A small metal medallion hangs from his neck.
LINA	A young woman, age 23. Short black hair, light brown skin and dark brown eyes. Wearing high waist jeans and a linen long sleeve button down and brown leather boots. <i>Same actress as Taloa</i>
LUKAS	<i>Same actor as Tomás.</i> [Offstage role]

SETTING

The shoreline of Southwest Florida, near present-day Naples.

TIME

The years 1498 and 2009.

PRODUCTION NOTES

The staging should remain spare and theatrical rather than fully naturalistic. The ocean is represented by lengths of blue, white, and pale pink silk manipulated by performers. Ocean sounds remain present throughout the play, rising and falling in volume with the action.

The changing light of morning, afternoon, sunset, and night may be suggested through focused lighting and colour projected against a simple cyclorama, scrim, or rear backdrop. Mangroves may be represented by painted or cut-out scenic flats.

Taloe's dwelling is a simple pole-frame shelter with a thatched roof, constructed from wood and plant materials (palmetto fronds). It is shown in partial section so that the interior remains visible to the audience. Scene changes should be minimal and fluid.

SCENES

SCENE 1	The shoreline	1498
SCENE 2	Taloe's Hut	1498
SCENE 3	Taloe's Hut	1498
SCENE 4	Taloe's Hut	1498
SCENE 5	The shoreline	1498
SCENE 6	The shoreline	2009

SCENE 1

(The shoreline. Morning. TALOA walks along the ocean's edge.)

TALOA

The same morning as always.

(She looks towards the village behind her)

They never bother me.

(She looks towards the far end of stage and notices TOMÁS lying in the sand partially in the water. He is on his back, palms turned upwards, eyes half open.)

What is that?

(She walks slowly towards TOMÁS, taking her time, afraid, then crouches down.)

A... man?

(She looks at his clothing and body, tilting her head in confusion.)

Strange clothing... too much of it. His hair... and his eyes... they are like the colour of the shallow water... Is he dea-

(TOMÁS groans, his head tilting slightly, eyes shutting tight.)

Oh! Alive?

(TALOA stares down at him for a moment, then looks towards the village in the distance, then back to him. She hesitates, then grabs him under the arms and drags him towards the hut.)

(Lights fade.)

SCENE 2

(The interior of TALOA'S hut.)

(TOMÁS lies on a bed of palmetto fronds. TALOA kneels beside him with a vessel of water. She raises his head carefully and helps him drink. Some of the water runs down his chin.)

TALOA

Slowly.

(She gives him a little more. TOMÁS winces when she touches the wound at his temple.)

I know. I know.

(She cleans the wound and presses herbs against it. TOMÁS makes a small sound of pain.)

You are very warm.

(She places the back of her hand against his forehead.)

Too warm.

(TOMÁS glances weakly towards the entrance of the hut. TALOA notices. She moves aside, leaving the entrance entirely unobstructed.)

TALOA

You can go.

(A pause.)

Though I do not think you can.

(She rises and crosses away from him.)

(Time passes. The light changes.)

(TALOA returns with food and sits several feet from him. She places it within his reach. TOMÁS looks at the food, then at her.)

TALOA

Eat?

(She demonstrates. TOMÁS takes some cautiously, only able to take small bites. TALOA watches until he catches her watching. She immediately looks elsewhere.)

TOMÁS

Dios os lo pague.

(TALOA turns back.)

TALOA

I do not know what that means.

(TOMÁS gives the faintest smile.)

TALOA

But you sound less frightened.

(She sits. A little later, she helps him drink again.)

You must have come from very far away.

(He watches her.)

Did the ocean carry you all that way?

(Nothing.)

Of course you cannot understand me.

(She studies him for a moment. Then touches her chest.)

Taloea.

(TOMÁS watches her hand.)

I. Am. Taloa.

(Understanding. TOMÁS touches his own chest.)

TOMÁS

Tomás.

TALOA

To-ma?

(TOMÁS gives a small rough laugh and shakes his head.)

TOMÁS

To-*más*.

TALOA

To-*más*.

TOMÁS

Sí. Tomás.

(He points gently towards her.)

Y vos, Taloa.

(Pause.)

Taloa.

(A long moment.)

TALOA

Yes.

(She smiles softly then points to herself.)

Talóa.

(She points to him.)

Tomás.

(Then herself.)

Talóa.

(Back to him.)

Tomás.

(TOMÁS smiles.)

You are Tomás. And I am Talóa.

(She looks towards the distant sound of
the sea.)

The ocean gave you to me.

(She looks back at him.)

So I will take care of you.

(TOMÁS smiles.)

(The light through the hut turns
orange-red as the sun lowers and TOMÁS falls asleep.)

(TALOA sits near the entrance listening
to his breathing. Eventually she lies down against the
opposite wall.)

(Whispered.)

Tomás.

(Lights fade.)

SCENE 3

(The hut. Late the following morning.)

(TOMÁS is awake. TALOA sits on the floor working with shells, drilled shell beads and cord.)

(For some time there is no dialogue.)

(TOMÁS watches her hands and TALOA becomes aware of him watching.)

TALOA

What?

(He continues watching.)

You make me nervous when you do that.

(She tries to continue working, fumbles slightly, then stops.)

See?

(TOMÁS smiles weakly.)

It is your fault.

(She goes back to work. Gradually she forgets that he is watching. Her hands find their rhythm.)

(TOMÁS shifts. Light catches the medallion around his neck. TALOA notices it.)

What is that?

(She gestures towards the medallion. TOMÁS looks down. He removes the medallion carefully and holds it towards her.)

TOMÁS
San Cristóbal.

TALOA
San...?

TOMÁS
Cristóbal.

(TALOA takes it and turns it over in her fingers, examining the unfamiliar figure and the worn metal.)

TALOA
Who is he?

(TOMÁS touches the figure.)

TOMÁS
San Cristóbal.

(TALOA looks towards the ocean.)

TALOA
Did he come through the water with you too?

(She gives the medallion back. TOMÁS takes it. Then he notices the shells spread around her. He looks at the medallion. The shells. Then TALOA. He holds the medallion out again and gestures towards her work.)

TALOA
You want—

(Pause.)

Oh.

(She smiles.)

Give it to me then.

(He gives her the medallion.)

(TALOA selects two shells. She takes her time and tests them against the medallion, rejects one, chooses another, threads cord and begins binding the objects together.)

(TOMÁS watches. TALOA occasionally glances at him.)

TALOA
My father taught me this.

(A pause as she works.)

His hands were much faster than mine.

(A pause.)

At least, I remember them that way.

(TALOA finishes the binding and lifts the completed necklace towards the light.)

There.

(She turns it so TOMÁS can see.)

Now it belongs.

(She places it in TOMÁS' hands. He studies it. His eyes become wet, a smile.)

TOMÁS
Es hermoso.

(TALOA smiles.)

Como vos.

TALOA
I still cannot understand you.

TOMÁS

Hermosa.

TALOA

You should rest.

(She places a hand against his shoulder and gently guides him backwards. TOMÁS keeps looking at her. TALOA becomes conscious of it.)

TALOA

What?

(He raises his hand and his fingertips touch her cheek.)

(TALOA does not move away.)

(A long pause, then she leans forward and kisses him softly on the lips. TOMÁS' hand moves into her hair. The necklace rests between their joined hands. Eventually TALOA pulls back. She is smiling.)

TALOA

Omala.

TOMÁS

O... mala?

TALOA

Omala.

(She touches his chest.)

You are cherished.

(She touches his cheek.)

You are seen.

TOMÁS

Omala.

(She looks away for a moment, then back at him.)

TALOA

Yes.

(She lies beside him, her head on his shoulder as they hold hands.)

TOMÁS

Me quedaré... os lo prometo.

TALOA

Whatever you said—

(She rests her head against his shoulder.)

I know it was something good.

(TOMÁS closes his eyes. TALOA watches him, then closes hers.)

(Lights fade.)

SCENE 4

(The hut. The following morning. The ocean is slightly louder.)

(TALOA wakes. She immediately notices something different. TOMÁS'S breathing is now slow and laboured.)

TALOA

Tomás?

(She touches his forehead.)

No.

(She gets water and kneels beside him.)

Drink.

(She raises his head. He manages only a little.)

Again.

(He cannot.)

All right.

(She lowers him back down, but TOMÁS tries to sit up.)

No.

(She places her hand against his chest. TOMÁS looks down at her hand. He covers it with his.)

TOMÁS

¿Os quedaréis... conmigo?

(TALOA looks at him. TOMÁS gently holds her hand in place. TALOA understands.)

TALOA

Yes.

(She lies beside him.)

I will stay.

(A long silence. Morning light moves slowly through the hut. TALOA gives him water when he can take it. Eventually TALOA begins speaking.)

I had a father.

(TOMÁS looks at her.)

He laughed before he spoke. You could hear him across the water.

(A small smile.)

He smelled of salt and smoke.

(The smile disappears.)

They said I would marry.

(TOMÁS listens.)

I saw the man three times.

(A pause.)

He died before nightfall. I did not even reach his family's house. When I arrived, he was already gone.

(She looks towards the entrance.)

After that, everyone looked at me differently.

(A pause.)

A few months later my father's hands changed.

(She looks at TOMÁS'S hand holding hers.)

When he held things, it was as if he could not feel them anymore.

(Pause.)

I watched his hands.

(Pause.)

Then he died too.

(Pause.)

They think it is me.

(TOMÁS'S expression changes, though he cannot understand.)

Sometimes I think it is me.

That there is something inside me that... takes people.

(A pause.)

They think if I stand too near them, it will find them too.

(She looks towards the sea.)

That is why I go there every morning. The ocean does not judge me. I stand there and it takes nothing.

(Her voice breaks.)

I can breathe there.

(She looks at him.)

I did not even touch the man I was supposed to marry.

(A pause.)

Not once.

(She shakes her head.)

And still...

(Long pause.)

I do not understand what I am.

(TOMÁS watches her.)

You do not understand what I am saying.

(A tearful laugh.)

And still I tell you.

(She wipes her face.)

I do not know why.

(A pause.)

I am afraid now that you will leave.

(Her eyes go to his chest.)

I want this to stay as it is.

I just—

(She cannot finish.)

(TOMÁS slowly raises his hand and touches her cheek. TALOA turns into his palm.)

TOMÁS

O-mala.

(TALOA closes her eyes.)

Taloea...

(He struggles for breath.)

Quisiera quedarme aquí con vos. Bástame haberos hallado...
veros.

(TALOA opens her eyes.)

No es culpa vuestra. No sois vos. Es la mar... o Dios.

(His thumb moves weakly against her cheek.)

No vos.

(TALOA does not know the words.)

(TOMÁS gives a tiny laugh that becomes a cough.)

TALOA

Do not.

(She steadies him.)

TOMÁS

Taloe, quedaos... por caridad.

(He catches his breath.)

Bástame esto: haberos visto.

(He looks directly at her.)

Fuisteis mi primer beso...

(A faint smile.)

...y me basta.

(TALOA'S eyes fill.)

Sois la más hermosa que mis ojos han visto.

TALOA

I wish I knew what you were saying.

(TOMÁS takes her hand.)

TOMÁS

Os quiero, Taloa.

(Silence.)

(TALOA closes her fingers around his.)

TALOA

Os... qui-ero... Tomás.

(They remain together. The light changes slowly from morning to afternoon. Then gold. Then red. TALOA lies her head on TOMÁS' shoulder once more. TOMÁS'S breathing becomes increasingly separated by long silences. TALOA moves her head to his chest.

TALOA

One.

(TOMÁS breathes.)

Two.

(TOMÁS breathes. Then a longer pause.)

Three.

(TOMÁS breathes.)

Tomás?

(His fingers move against hers.)

I am here.

(TOMÁS takes another breath.)

(Pause.)

(Another breath.)

(Long silence.)

(TALOA waits.)

TALOA

Tomás?

(Nothing. She watches his chest. Lights fade to grey wash. TALOA waits for another breath. There is none.)

No.

(She waits.)

No, you have to—

(She touches his chest.)

Tomás?

(Nothing.)

(TALOA sits absolutely still.)

(A long silence.)

(Then she begins to cry, her head on his chest.)

You said my name.

(She looks at him.)

You said it as if there was nothing wrong with it.

(She lifts his hand and presses it against her lips.)

Tomás.

(She places his hand over his heart.)

(Lights fade.)

SCENE 5

(The hut. Sunset. Orange-golden light.)

(TALOA kneels near the base of the hut outside of it. The necklace lies in her hand. She looks at TOMÁS inside.)

TALOA

You gave it to me.

(She looks down at the necklace.)

Or perhaps I gave it to you?

(A faint, broken smile.)

I suppose neither of us knew.

(She digs into the earth with her hands and places the necklace in the hollow.)

This stays.

(She covers it, pressing her palms flat against the earth.)

(A pause.)

(She crosses back to TOMÁS in the hut.)

Come.

(She gathers him beneath the arms.)

You are heavier now.

(She begins dragging him.)

(She stops to breathe.)

(As TALOA moves, the hut disappears into darkness. Mangrove shapes pass around her. The sound of the ocean gradually increases.)

I wish you could tell me where you came from.

(She pulls him onwards.)

Whether there was someone waiting for you.

(A pause.)

Whether you were frightened when the water took you.

(The mangroves open. The silk ocean becomes visible. Stars begin appearing as the sun sets. TALOA reaches the shoreline. She stands looking at it.)

The same ocean.

(She looks down at TOMÁS.)

It gave you to me.

(A long pause.)

(She steps into the silk. The performers begin moving it gently around her ankles.)

(TALOA pulls TOMÁS after her.)

I came here after he died.

(She walks deeper.)

And after my father.

(Deeper.)

And every morning when I could not stand them looking at me.

(The ocean reaches her waist.)

It never asked me anything. It asks nothing now.

(She gathers TOMÁS closer as the silk supports and surrounds them.)

Look.

(She looks upwards, then back down at TOMÁS, a sad smile on her face.)

You are lighter here. And I am as well.

(She takes his hand.)

Tomás. Omala...

(The words are almost lost beneath the sound of the water.)

(TALOA turns her head. Far behind her is the dark outline of the village. She watches it. Then she looks down at their joined hands. Then towards the open ocean.)

(She continues walking. The silk rises. The ocean becomes louder. TALOA keeps hold of TOMÁS'S hand. The silk closes over them.)

(The ocean sound reaches its height.)

(Lights fade to black.)

(Ocean sound fades slowly, then silence.)

SCENE 6

(Curtains open to the same shoreline. Approximately five hundred years later. Late afternoon. The hut is gone. A small archaeological work area occupies the place where it once stood. LINA kneels over a sorting cloth with bags, tags, pottery sherds and worked bone. The necklace TALOA made is on a small folding table.)

LINA

NP-7.

(She writes.)

Disturbed context. Adjacent to posthole features.

(She examines the necklace.)

Probable Calusa origin. Pre-contact suspected.

(She picks up the necklace and turns it over.)

But you—

(She looks closer at the medallion.)

—you are *not* supposed to be here.

(She puts the necklace back on the table and takes some more photographs with her phone, a BlackBerry Bold 9000. After, she types into the phone for a moment, then puts it in her back pocket.)

(She sighs, picking up the necklace once more and examines the cord.)

How did you survive?

(She looks towards the place where the hut had been on stage.)

Someone sat here and made you.

(She studies the necklace again. Then puts it back. She writes in her notebook for a long while.)

(Her phone rings. She pulls it out of her pocket, frowning. Then she looks down at it and smiles. She answers.)

Oh. Hallo Lukas.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

You still at the site?

LINA

Yeah, but I'm about to pack up and head back.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

I was looking at those photographs you sent over.

LINA

Of course you were.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

The necklace.

LINA

Well I assumed you didn't mean the broken pottery.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

(He laughs.)

No. But... the way it's made. The materials... The medallion...

(Pause.)

(LINA looks back at the necklace.)

It doesn't feel ceremonial.

LINA

No.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

It feels... well... personal.

(A pause.)

LINA

I've been thinking that too.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Perhaps it was a gift?

(LINA picks up the necklace and looks closely at the medallion between the shells.)

Or something two people made to represent something important?

(LINA looks towards the ocean.)

LINA

We can't prove that.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

I know.

LINA

Could be exchange.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Could be.

LINA

Or salvage from a wreck. Someone found a foreign object and worked it into something local.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Perfectly reasonable.

LINA

Annoyingly reasonable.

(LUKAS laughs.)

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Still.

LINA

Still what?

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

I keep thinking about it.

(Pause.)

Anyway—

(Pause.)

If you're not too exhausted... Do you... wanna get dinner? When you're back I mean? I'd... I'd like to see you... Lina.

(LINA studies the necklace once more, then sets it back down.)

LINA

I think you're right.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

About dinner?

LINA

About the necklace.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Oh.

LINA

And dinner.

(She gives small smile.)

I'd... like to see you too, Lukas.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Ah- I- Good. I mean, that's good. That's really-

LINA

I'll call you when I'm back.

LUKAS (OFFSTAGE)

Okay. I'll be waiting. For your call I mean. And dinner.
And-

(He sighs.)

Drive safe... Lina.

LINA

I will.

(The call ends. LINA remains where she is, then puts the phone back in her pocket and picks up the necklace.)

Five hundred years.

(Pause.)

And this is what you left us.

(Pause.)

One small proof.

(LINA smiles then carefully places the necklace in its box then gathers her things as the Gulf begins turning gold. She begins to walk towards offstage then stops before leaving and looks towards the ocean and smiles.)

(LINA exits.)

(Lights fade.)

END OF PLAY